Notation

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Mathematical notation is not standardized. This section states the conventions these notes use, and the alternatives you may meet in other sources.

Table 1: Notation used in this book

symbol	meaning	LaTeX
$\neg$	not	`\neg`
$\forall$	for all	`\forall`
$\exists$	there exists	`\exists`
$\cup$	union, "or"	`\cup`
$\cap$	intersection, "and"	`\cap`
$\mid$	given, conditional on	`\mid`, `|`
$\sum$	sum	`\sum`
$\prod$	product	`\prod`
μ	mean, $\mathrm{E}[X]$, of a random variable X	`\mu`
E	expectation	`\mathbb{E}`
$x^\top$	transpose of x	`x\'`
$'$	transpose or derivative[1]	`'`
$\perp\!\!\!\perp$	independent	`\perp\!\!\!\perp`
$\therefore$	therefore, thus	`\therefore`
η	linear predictor of a generalized linear model[2]	`\eta`
$\lfloor x \rfloor$	floor of x: largest integer less than or equal to x	`\lfloor x \rfloor`
$\lceil x \rceil$	ceiling of x: smallest integer greater than or equal to x	`\lceil x \rceil`
$\mathbb{1}_A(x)$, $\mathbb{1}(P)$	indicator function (Section): 1 if condition holds, 0 otherwise	`\indic{A}(x)`, `\indicp{P}`

[1] depending on whether it is applied to a matrix or a function

[2] A generalized linear model (GLM) is a regression model in which a chosen function g, the link function, of the mean μ of the outcome equals the linear predictor $\eta = x^\top \beta$, a linear combination of the predictor values x with coefficients β: $g(\mu) = \eta$.

The links for conditioning, random variables, expectation, and independence go to the Morrison Lab's probability notes, which define those terms.

Writing math in Quarto

The third column of Table 1 gives the LaTeX command for each symbol. Quarto and R Markdown documents write math in LaTeX syntax: put inline math between single dollar signs, as in `$x^2$`, and displayed equations between double dollar signs, as in `$$x^2$$`. The equations section of Quarto's Markdown guide shows the details. These notes also use shorthand macros, such as `\floor{x}` for $\lfloor x \rfloor$, defined in the `latex-macros` submodule's `macros.qmd`.

Indicator functions

An **indicator function** is a mathematical function that signals whether an element belongs to a specified set, or whether a given logical condition is satisfied. In statistics and epidemiology, indicator functions are ubiquitous. They represent:

- binary variables, which take only the values 0 and 1 (Definition 0.3);
- event and censoring indicators in survival analysis, the study of the time until an event such as death, where an observation is censored when follow-up ends before its event is seen;
- membership in subpopulations;
- domain restrictions in integrals and sums.

Despite their conceptual simplicity, notation for indicator functions varies substantially across textbooks, research papers, and subfields. This section summarizes the principal notational conventions.

Definition 0.1 (Indicator function (set indicator))**.** For any subset $A \subseteq \Omega$ of a universal set Ω, the **indicator function** of A, or **set indicator**, is the function $\mathbb{1}_A : \Omega \to \{0, 1\}$ defined by:

$$\mathbb{1}_A(x) \stackrel{\text{def}}{=} \begin{cases} 1, & x \in A \\ 0, & x \notin A \end{cases}$$

Definition 0.2 (Predicate indicator)**.** For any logical proposition or predicate P, the **indicator** of P, or **predicate indicator**, takes the value 1 when P is true and 0 when P is false:

$$\mathbb{1}(P) \stackrel{\text{def}}{=} \begin{cases} 1, & \text{if } P \text{ is true} \\ 0, & \text{if } P \text{ is false} \end{cases}$$

Example 0.1 (Evaluating set and predicate indicators)**.** Consider the real line $\Omega = \mathbb{R}$, the set of nonnegative numbers $A = [0, \infty)$, and a continuous random variable Y (defined in the Morrison Lab's probability notes).

1. Set indicator $\mathbb{1}_A(x)$:
   - For $x = 3.5$: since $3.5 \in [0, \infty)$, $\mathbb{1}_A(3.5) = 1$.
   - For $x = -2.1$: since $-2.1 \notin [0, \infty)$, $\mathbb{1}_A(-2.1) = 0$.
2. Predicate indicator $\mathbb{1}(Y > 5)$:
   - If an observation yields $Y = 7.2$, the predicate $7.2 > 5$ is true, so $\mathbb{1}(7.2 > 5) = 1$.
   - If an observation yields $Y = 4.1$, the predicate $4.1 > 5$ is false, so $\mathbb{1}(4.1 > 5) = 0$.

Definition 0.3 (Binary variable)**.** A **binary variable** is a variable that takes only the values 0 and 1.

Example 0.2 (A binary variable is an indicator)**.** In a study of n people, let $s_i = 1$ if person i smokes and $s_i = 0$ otherwise, for $i \in \{1, \dots, n\}$. Then s_i is a binary variable (Definition 0.3). It is also the predicate indicator (Definition 0.1) of the proposition "person i smokes": $s_i = \mathbb{1}(\text{person } i \text{ smokes})$.
In the same way, every indicator is a binary variable, and every binary variable X is the indicator of its own value being 1: $X = \mathbb{1}(X = 1)$, since both sides are 1 when $X = 1$ and 0 when $X = 0$.

Two primary notational paradigms: set vs. predicate notation

The vast majority of indicator notations belong to one of two families: set notation or predicate notation.

Definition 0.4 (Set notation for indicators)**.** An indicator (Definition 0.1) is written in **set notation** when the set A appears as a subscript, as in $\mathbb{1}_A(x)$.

Definition 0.5 (Predicate notation for indicators)**.** An indicator (Definition 0.1) is written in **predicate notation** when a proposition or predicate P (definition) appears as

its argument, as in $\mathbb{1}(P)$ or $\mathbb{1}(x \in A)$.

Example 0.3 (One indicator in both notations)**.** Let $A = [0, \infty)$, the nonnegative real numbers. The indicator of A is $\mathbb{1}_A(x)$ in set notation, and $\mathbb{1}(x \in A)$ or $\mathbb{1}(x \geq 0)$ in predicate notation (Definition 0.4, Definition 0.5). At $x = 3.5$, all three equal 1; at $x = -2.1$, all three equal 0.

Set notation

In set notation, the indicator is tied to a set A, which appears as a subscript:

- $\mathbf{1}_A(x)$ (bold numeral one)
- $\mathbb{1}_A(x)$ (blackboard bold numeral one)
- $I_A(x)$ (capital letter I)
- $\mathbb{I}_A(x)$ (blackboard bold letter I)
- $\chi_A(x)$ (Greek letter chi, historically termed the *characteristic function*)

When the function is viewed as a mathematical object in its own right (for instance, as an element of an L^p function space, the set of functions f for which $\int |f(x)|^p \, dx$ is finite), authors often omit the argument x, writing simply $\mathbf{1}_A$, $\mathbb{1}_A$, or I_A.

Predicate notation

In predicate notation, the indicator takes a logical condition, relation, or proposition P directly as its argument or subscript:

- $\mathbb{I}(x \in A)$ or $\mathbb{I}(P)$
- $\mathbf{1}(x \in A)$ or $\mathbf{1}(P)$
- $\mathbb{1}(x \in A)$ or $\mathbb{1}(P)$
- $\mathbb{1}\{x \in A\}$ or $\mathbb{1}\{P\}$
- $I(x \in A)$ or $I(P)$

Predicate notation is especially common in applied statistics and survival analysis, where indicators frequently depend on inequalities (definition) involving random variables, such as $\mathbb{1}(T_i \leq t)$ (an event occurring before time t) or $\mathbb{1}(Y_i = 1)$ (a binary outcome).

Equivalence between paradigms

The two paradigms are connected by evaluating the predicate indicator at the membership statement $x \in A$:

$$\mathbf{1}_A(x) = \mathbb{I}(x \in A)$$

Definition 0.6 (Support of a distribution)**.** The **support** of a discrete distribution is the set of values it gives positive probability. The support of a continuous distribution is the set of values where its density is positive.

Example 0.4 (Supports of two count distributions)**.**

- A fair six-sided die gives each of $1, 2, \ldots, 6$ probability $\frac{1}{6} > 0$ and every other value probability 0, so its support is $\{1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6\}$.
- A count that can be 0, 1, 2, and so on, each with positive probability, such as the number of hospital visits in a year, has support $\mathbb{N}_0 = \{0, 1, 2, \ldots\}$.

Set notation is more natural when the underlying set A has a standard name (such as the support of a distribution (Definition 0.6), or a geometric region). Predicate notation is more natural when the condition involves compound inequalities, such as $\mathbb{1}(0 \leq t \leq u)$.

Iverson bracket notation

In 1962, Kenneth Iverson introduced a compact notation in the programming language APL, later popularized in mathematics and computer science by Donald Knuth: the Iverson bracket.

Definition 0.7 (Iverson bracket)**.** For any logical proposition P, the **Iverson bracket** of P is

$$[P] \stackrel{\text{def}}{=} \begin{cases} 1, & \text{if } P \text{ is true} \\ 0, & \text{if } P \text{ is false} \end{cases}$$

Example 0.5 (Evaluating Iverson brackets)**.**

- $[3 > 2] = 1$, because $3 > 2$ is true.
- $[2 > 3] = 0$, because $2 > 3$ is false.
- $[4 \in \{1, 2\}] = 0$, because 4 is not an element of $\{1, 2\}$.

ℹ Remark (The Iverson bracket is the predicate indicator)

Remark 0.1 (The Iverson bracket is the predicate indicator). The Iverson bracket $[P]$ is the predicate indicator $\mathbb{1}(P)$ (Definition 0.1) in different notation. Under this notation,

set membership is written $[x \in A]$, so $[x \in A] = \mathbb{1}_A(x)$. For example, the values in Example 0.1 become

$$\begin{aligned}[7.2 > 5] &= \mathbb{1}(7.2 > 5) \\ &= 1\end{aligned}$$

and, with $A = [0, \infty)$,

$$\begin{aligned}[-2.1 \in A] &= \mathbb{1}_A(-2.1) \\ &= 0.\end{aligned}$$

Definition 0.8 (Kronecker delta)**.** For integers i and j, the **Kronecker delta** is

$$\delta_{ij} \stackrel{\text{def}}{=} [i = j]$$

that is, $\delta_{ij} = 1$ when $i = j$ and $\delta_{ij} = 0$ when $i \neq j$ (Definition 0.7).

Example 0.6 (Evaluating the Kronecker delta)**.**

- $$\begin{aligned}\delta_{11} &= [1 = 1] \\ &= 1.\end{aligned}$$
- $$\begin{aligned}\delta_{12} &= [1 = 2] \\ &= 0.\end{aligned}$$
- $$\begin{aligned}\delta_{22} &= [2 = 2] \\ &= 1.\end{aligned}$$
- $$\begin{aligned}\delta_{23} &= [2 = 3] \\ &= 0.\end{aligned}$$

Strengths and limitations of the Iverson bracket

The primary advantage of the Iverson bracket is algebraic conciseness: it turns a sum or integral over a subset into a sum or integral over a larger, fixed set. For example, if U is a finite set that contains A, then:

$$\sum_{x \in A} f(x) = \sum_{x \in U} f(x)[x \in A]$$

With $A = \{2, 4\}$, $f(x) = x$, and $U = \{1, 2, 3, 4, 5\}$, both sides equal $2 + 4 = 6$.

However, in statistics and epidemiology, square brackets are already heavily overloaded: they denote closed intervals $[a, b]$, conditional expectations $\mathrm{E}[Y \mid X]$ (defined in the probability notes), and matrix delimiters. To prevent visual confusion with expectation brackets or intervals, statistical literature predominantly uses $\mathbb{1}$ or I rather than the bare Iverson bracket.

Summary of indicator notations

Table 2 compares the major notations encountered across the literature.

Table 2: Notations for indicator functions across mathematical and statistical literature

Notation style	Typical syntax	Primary fields	Notes and potential ambiguities
Blackboard bold 1	$\mathbb{1}_A(x)$, $\mathbb{1}(P)$	Modern probability, mathematical statistics	Unambiguous; distinct from matrices and scalars; standard in this book.
Bold numeral 1	$\mathbf{1}_A(x)$, $\mathbf{1}(P)$	Probability theory, measure theory	Can be confused with a vector of ones $\mathbf{1} = (1, \ldots, 1)^\top$.
Blackboard bold I	$\mathbb{I}(x \in A)$, $\mathbb{I}(P)$	Econometrics, machine learning, statistics	Clear predicate notation; avoids confusion with numerals.
Letter I	$I_A(x)$, $I(P)$	Classical statistics, epidemiology	Can be confused with the identity matrix I or the Fisher information $\mathcal{I}$, which measures how much a sample tells about a parameter.
Iverson bracket	$[P]$, $[x \in A]$	Computer science, discrete mathematics	Very compact, but square brackets collide with intervals and expectation brackets.
Greek letter χ	$\chi_A(x)$	Real analysis, measure theory	Often termed "characteristic function"; in probability, that name instead means $t \mapsto \mathrm{E}[e^{itX}]$ for a random variable X.

Conventions in this book

In these notes, we standardize on blackboard bold $\mathbb{1}$ via the macros defined in `latex-macros/macros.qmd`:

- `\indic{A}` produces $\mathbb{1}_A$ (set subscript)
- `\indicp{P}` produces $\mathbb{1}(P)$ (predicate in parentheses)
- `\indiccb{P}` produces $\mathbb{1}\{P\}$ (predicate in curly braces)
- `\1{P}` produces 1_P (text numeral with subscript, used in legacy formulas)

Blackboard bold $\mathbb{1}$ is preferred because it avoids all common collisions: it is visually distinct from the scalar 1, the identity matrix I, and the observed and expected Fisher information matrices (I, $\mathcal{I}$).

Key algebraic properties

Indicator functions translate the logical connectives (definition) "and", "or", and "not", applied to set membership, into ordinary arithmetic on real numbers. One of the identities below uses idempotence:

Definition 0.9 (Idempotent)**.** A number a is **idempotent** if $a \cdot a = a$. A function f with real values is **idempotent** if $f(x) \cdot f(x) = f(x)$ for every x in its domain.

Example 0.7 (Idempotent numbers and indicators)**.**

- 0 and 1 are idempotent: $0 \cdot 0 = 0$ and $1 \cdot 1 = 1$.
- 2 is not idempotent: $2 \cdot 2 = 4 \neq 2$.
- Every indicator function $\mathbb{1}_A$ is idempotent, because each of its values is 0 or 1. For example, with $A = [0, \infty)$,

$$\begin{aligned} \mathbb{1}_A(3.5) \cdot \mathbb{1}_A(3.5) &= 1 \cdot 1 \\ &= 1 \\ &= \mathbb{1}_A(3.5). \end{aligned}$$

The idempotent matrices of linear algebra satisfy the same equation with matrix multiplication: $\mathbf{M}^2 = \mathbf{M}$ for a square matrix $\mathbf{M}$.

For subsets A and B of Ω, with complement $A^c \stackrel{\text{def}}{=} \Omega \setminus A$, and for every $x \in \Omega$:

- **Intersection ("and"):** $\mathbb{1}_{A \cap B}(x) = \mathbb{1}_A(x) \cdot \mathbb{1}_B(x)$

- **Union ("or"):** $\mathbb{1}_{A\cup B}(x) = \mathbb{1}_A(x) + \mathbb{1}_B(x) - \mathbb{1}_A(x) \cdot \mathbb{1}_B(x)$
- **Complement ("not"):** $\mathbb{1}_{A^c}(x) = 1 - \mathbb{1}_A(x)$
- **Idempotence (Definition 0.9):** $(\mathbb{1}_A(x))^2 = \mathbb{1}_A(x)$
- **Expectation gives probability:** When Ω is a sample space and A is an event, the expectation of its indicator is the probability of the event (all four terms are defined in the Morrison Lab's probability notes):

$$\begin{aligned} \mathrm{E}[\mathbb{1}_A] &= 0 \cdot \Pr(A^c) + 1 \cdot \Pr(A) \\ &= \Pr(A) \end{aligned}$$

This identity turns probabilities into expectations. It is the mathematical foundation for:

- empirical proportions;
- estimators of survival curves, the probability of no event by each time;
- regression models for binary outcomes.

Why is notation in probability and statistics so inconsistent and disorganized?

In grad school, we are asked to learn from increasingly disorganized materials and lectures. Not coincidentally, as the amount of organization decreases, the amount of complexity increases, the amount of difficulty increases, the number of reliable references decreases, and the amount of inconsistency in notation and content increases (both between multiple references and within single references!). In other words, as you approach the cutting-edge of most fields, you start to run into content that hasn't been fully thought through or standardized. This lack of clarity is unfortunate and undesirable, but it is understandable and inevitable.

It's worth noting that calculus was formalized in the 1600s, elementary algebra was formalized around 820, and arithmetic even earlier. And calculus still has several competing notation systems. In contrast, the field of statistics only emerged in the late 1800s and early 1900s, so it's not surprising that the notation and terminology is still developing. Generalized linear models were only formalized in 1972 (Nelder and Wedderburn 1972), which is very recent in terms of the pace of scientific development.

Further reading

For the logical symbols and proof conventions used in these notes (whose definitions are on the Proof Writing page):

- Velleman (2019) explains how mathematical statements are built from logical connectives (definition) and quantifiers (definition), and how to read and write them.

- Barker-Plummer et al. (2011) covers the same symbols as a formal language, with propositional logic (the logic of connectives) and first-order logic (which adds quantifiers).

For set and function notation, see the Sets, Functions, and Expressions and Algorithms pages.

References

Barker-Plummer, Dave, Jon Barwise, and John Etchemendy. 2011. *Language, Proof and Logic*. 2nd ed. CSLI Publications. https://www.amazon.com/dp/1575866323.

Nelder, John Ashworth, and Robert WM Wedderburn. 1972. "Generalized Linear Models." *Journal of the Royal Statistical Society Series A: Statistics in Society* 135 (3): 370–84. https://doi.org/10.2307/2344614.

Velleman, Daniel J. 2019. *How to Prove It: A Structured Approach*. 3rd ed. Cambridge University Press. https://doi.org/10.1017/9781108539890.